

Aromatic Herbs that Transform Dampness

- Aromatic and fragrant
- Enhance the function of the Spleen to dissolve, dry, and disperse dampness.
- Transform and transport substances that would otherwise accumulate to cause dampness
- Differential diagnosis: Damp-cold, damp-heat, etc.; Combine with other herbs.
- Long-term use of warming and drying herbs may consume yin and body fluids.
- Most of these herbs are aromatic and contain large percentages of essential oils. They should be added toward the end of the decoction.
- Beneficial to use with herbs that simultaneously activate qi.

Name	Similarities	Differences
Cang Zhu (<i>Rhizoma Atractylodis</i>)	Strong aromatic properties to dry dampness	Strongly dries dampness, strengthens the Spleen, dispels wind-dampness, and improves vision.
Hou Po (<i>Cortex Magnoliae Officinalis</i>)		Promotes qi movement, dries dampness, relieves bloating and distention, descends Lung qi, arrests wheezing
Huo Xiang (<i>Herba Agastache</i>)	Aromatically transform dampness in the middle Jiao, relieve summer-heat	Harmonize middle jiao to stop vomiting, release exterior, and transforms turbid dampness
Pei Lan (<i>Herba Eupatorii</i>)		Mildly releases the exterior.
Sha Ren (<i>Fructus Amomi</i>)	Regulate qi, transform dampness, warm the middle Jiao	Treats nausea, vomiting, and diarrhea due to coldness. Stabilizes the fetus
Bai Dou Kou (<i>Fructus Amomi Rotundus</i>)		Transforms dampness in the middle and upper jiaos, most suitable for the initial stages of vomiting
Cao Guo (<i>Fructus Tsaolo</i>)	Warmer property, dry dampness, warm middle jiao	Strongly dries dampness, treats malaria
Cao Dou Kou (<i>Semen Alpiniae Katsumadai</i>)		Treats Spleen and Stomach cold dampness

Cāng Zhú 苍术 “gray rhizome” “gray essence”

- Rhizoma Atractylodis
- English: atractylodes (black) rhizome
- Properties: acrid, bitter, warm, aromatic

- Channels: Spleen, Stomach

Actions and Indications

Actions: Strongly dries dampness and strengthens the Spleen.

Indications – for dampness obstructing the middle burner and blocking the T+T functions of the Spleen.

Note: Cang Zhu is Yao Yao for dampness obstructing the middle jiao.

- Accumulation of dampness in the Spleen-Hou Po, Chen Pi (Formula: ping wei san)
- Diarrhea due to accumulation of dampness-Bai Zhu, Fu Ling, Yi Yi Ren

Actions: Expels wind-cold dampness

Indications – for painful obstruction due to wind-cold-dampness.

- Bi zheng with swelling and pain-Fen Fang Ji, Yi Yi Ren
- Bi zheng with knee pain and swelling, muscle weakness or atrophy and difficulty walking due to damp-heat in lower part of the body-Huang Bai (Formula: er miao san)

Actions: Induces sweating and releases the exterior.

Indications – fever, chills, headache, body aches, nasal congestion and absence of sweat.
+ Qiang Huo, Fang Feng

Actions: Clears dampness in the lower burner

Indications – for damp heat pouring downward (as in leg qi), vaginal discharge and swollen, sore joints.

Actions: Improves vision

Indications – for night blindness, diminished vision, cataracts, and glaucoma.

Traditionally, Cang Zhu is used with food. It can be used alone or cooked with pig or goat liver.

Main Actions:

- Dries dampness, strengthens the Spleen
- Dispels wind-dampness.

Dosage: 5 to 10 grams.

Cautions: Yin-deficient heat or patients who have spontaneous perspiration due to Wei Qi deficiency.

Notes: Unprocessed Cang Zhu is very dry in nature and strongly dispels dampness. Dry-frying the herb significantly reduces its drying property and its effectiveness in dispelling dampness. Therefore, dry-fried Cang Zhu is generally used to bind the intestines and stop diarrhea.

Review questions:

- What are the common actions and cautions of the Aromatic herbs that transform Dampness?
- What is the treatment principle for treating dampness obstructing the middle jiao?
- What are the actions and indications of Cang Zhu?
- Which herb is a “yao yao” to strongly dry dampness and strengthen the Spleen?
- What are the clinic indications of Cang Zhu (dampness obstruction, Bi (cold + heat) and EPI) and possible combination of the herbs?
- What are the specific cautions for Cang Zhu?

Hòu Pò 厚朴

- Cortex Magnoliae Officinalis
- English: magnolia bark
- Properties: bitter, acrid, warm, aromatic
- Channels: Large Intestine, Lung, Spleen, Stomach

Actions and Indications

Actions: Promotes the movement of qi, transforms damp, and resolves stagnation.

Indications – dampness distressing the middle jiao, qi stagnation of the Spleen and Stomach, and food stagnation.

Note: Hou Po is the key herb (Yao Yao) for treating qi stagnation of the Spleen and Stomach, leading to epigastric and abdominal fullness and distention, loss of appetite, and poor digestion.

- Dampness obstructing the middle jiao: Cang Zhu, Chen Pi (Formula: ping wei san)
- Food stagnation with constipation: Da Huang, Zhi Shi (Formula: da xiao cheng qi tang)
- Qi stagnation with cold: Gui Zhi, Fu Zi, Gan Jiang
- Qi stagnation with deficient cold: Ren Shen, Gan Cao, Sheng Jiang

Actions: Warms and transforms phlegm and directs rebellious qi downward.

Indications – for wheezing, primarily due to phlegm obstruction, with cough and a stifling sensation in the chest.

Main Actions:

- Regulates qi
- Dries dampness
- Reduces stagnation
- Arrests wheezing

Dosage: 3-10 grams in decoction.

Cautions: during pregnancy or Qi deficiency.

Review Questions

What are the actions and indications of Hou Po?

What is the direction of movement for Hou Po?

What is a “yao yao” for qi stagnation at the middle jiao?

Which herb regulates qi, dries dampness, reduces stagnation, and arrests wheezing?

What are the possible indications of combinations of Cang Zhu and Hou po?

Huò Xiāng 藿香 “aromatic bean leaf”

- Herba Agastaches seu Pogostemi
- English: agastache; patchouli, pogostemon
- Properties: acrid, slightly warm
- Channels: Lung, Spleen, Stomach

Actions and Indications

Actions: Aromatically transforms dampness

Indications – for turbid dampness creating internal obstruction, specifically in the middle jiao.

+ Cang Zhu, Hou Po, Ban Xia

Actions: Releases the exterior and transforms turbidity

Indications – Used for exterior disorders with dampness, including the early stages of damp warm-febrile diseases or summer-heat, as well as externally contracted wind-cold with internal injury from dampness.

Notes: Huo Xiang is warm without dryness. It transforms turbidity, harmonizes the middle jiao, and is an excellent herb to dispel summer–dampness from both the interior and exterior.

- Summer-dampness with wind-cold-Zi Su Ye, Bai Zhi, Hou Po (Formula: huo xiang zheng qi san)

Actions: Harmonizes the middle burner and stops vomiting

Indications – most commonly used for nausea or vomiting due to dampness obstructing the middle burner

Actions: Reduces Nausea and vomiting due to turbid dampness

It can be used alone or combined with Ban Xia.

- Nausea and vomiting due to damp-heat-Huang Lian, Zhu Ru
- Nausea and vomiting with Spleen and Stomach deficiency-Dang Shen, Gan Cao
- Nausea and vomiting during pregnancy-Ban Xia, Sha Ren

Main Actions:

- Transforms dampness
- Releases the exterior & dispels summer-damp
- Relieves nausea and vomiting

Dosage: 5-10 grams

Note: Double the dosage if the fresh form is used. Huo Xiang is generally added to the decoction at the end of the cooking.

Review questions

What are the actions & indications of Huo Xiang?

Which herb treats turbid dampness (EPI)?

Which herb harmonizes the middle Jiao and stops vomiting? (type of nausea with possible herb combinations)

What are the special cooking instructions of Huo Xiang?

Sha Rén 砂仁 “sand seeds”

- Fructus Amomi
- English: grains-of-paradise fruit, amomum fruit
- Properties: acrid, warm, aromatic
- Channels: Spleen, Stomach

Actions and Indications

Actions: Transforms dampness and regulates qi

Indications – used when dampness distresses the Spleen or Stomach causing discomfort in the epigastrium, nausea, abdominal pain and diarrhea

Actions: Acrid, warm and aromatic

Indications-Restores normal T & T function. Common herb for “xing pi he wei”

- Dampness obstructing middle jiao-Hou Po, Cang Zhu, Bai Dou Kou
- Spleen and Stomach qi stagnation-Mu Xiang
- Food stagnation with indigestion-Lai Fu Zi, Shan Zha, Zhi Shi
- Spleen and Stomach deficiency-Dang Shen, Bai Zhu, Fu Ling

Indications-Sha Ren is commonly used to relieve bloating, spasms and pain

Actions: Warms the middle jiao, stops diarrhea

Indications – for cold and damp accumulating in the middle jiao, manifesting as diarrhea.
+ Gan Jiang, Fu Zi

Actions: Calms the fetus, stabilizes pregnancy

Indications – for morning sickness or restless fetus. Zi Su Gen, Sheng Jiang, Bai Zhu

Main Actions:

- Transforms dampness
- Regulates qi
- Warms the middle jiao
- Calms the fetus

Dosage: 3-6 grams.

Note: Added last to the decoction, as prolonged cooking destroys its effectiveness.

Review questions:

- What are the actions and indications of Sha Ren?
- What is the special action of Sha Ren on the middle jiao? “xing pi he wei”
- Which herbs treat morning sickness and restless fetus?
- What are the special cooking instructions of Sha Ren?

Bái Dòu Kòu 白豆蔻

“white cardamom”

- Fructus Amomi Rotundus
- English: round cardamom fruit, cluster
- Properties: acrid, warm, aromatic
- Channels: Lung, Spleen, Stomach

Actions and Indications

Actions: Aromatically transforms dampness, regulates qi

Indications – damp obstructing middle jiao leading to epigastric and abdominal fullness, distention, lack of appetite, and a greasy tongue coat.

Actions: Warms the middle burner, regulates qi, and causes rebellious qi to descend

Indications – for vomiting due to cold from deficiency of the Spleen and Stomach or Stomach cold. + Huo Xiang, Ban Xia

Main Actions

- Transforms dampness
- Regulates qi
- Warms the middle jiao
- Relieves nausea

Dosage: 3-6 grams.

Notes:

- Crush the Bai Dou Kou and add it toward the end of the decoction.
- The properties and actions of Bai Dou Kou and Sha Ren are very similar.
- They both transform dampness, regulate qi, and warm the middle jiao.
- They both benefit the stomach and reduce food stagnation.
- Bai Dou Kou tends to regulate qi in the upper and middle jiao. (Lung, Spleen, Stomach)
- Sha Ren tends to regulate qi in the middle and lower jiao, so it warms the Spleen and stops diarrhea.

Review questions:

- What are the actions and indications of Bai Dou Kou?
- Compare Sha Ren and Bai Dou Kou.
- What are the special cooling instructions of Bai Dou Kou?

Cao Dòu Kòu 草豆蔻 “grass cardamom”

- Semen Alpiniae Katsumadai
- English: Katsumada’s galangal seeds
- Properties: acrid, warm, aromatic
- Channels: Spleen, Stomach

Actions and Indications

Actions: Dries dampness and warms the middle jiao

Indications – for damp-cold of the Spleen and Stomach.

Main Actions:

- Dries dampness, warms the middle jiao, and regulates qi.

Dosage: 3-6 grams. It should be added at the end of decoction.

Cautions: Cao Dou Kou is contraindicated in patients who have yin or blood deficiencies.

Review questions:

- Compare Sha Ren, Bai Dou Kou, and Cao Dou Kou
- What are the special cooking instructions of Cao Dou Kou?

Cao Guo 草果 “grass fruit”

- Fructus Amomi Tsao-ko
- English: tsaoko fruit
- Properties: acrid, warm
- Channels: Spleen, Stomach

Actions and Indications

Actions: Strongly dries dampness and disperses cold

Indications – for damp-cold obstructing the Spleen and Stomach. If there is a greasy tongue coating, + Cang Zhu, Hou Po, Ban Xia

Actions: Checks malarial disorders

Indications – for intermittent fever and chills associated with malarial disorders, especially when due to damp-cold or turbid dampness

Main Actions:

- Dries dampness
- Warms the middle jiao
- Treats malaria

Dosage: 3-6 grams.

Review questions:

- What are the actions and Indications of Cao Guo?
- Which herbs treat malaria?

Pèi Lán 佩兰 “wearing orchid” “ornamental orchid”

- Herba Eupatorii Fortunei
- English: eupatorium
- Properties: acrid, neutral

- Channels: Spleen, Stomach

Actions and Indications

Actions: Aromatically transforms dampness

Indications – for dampness obstructing the middle burner with such symptoms as a stifling sensation in the chest, lack of appetite, nausea, and a white, moist tongue coat.

Notes:

- Pei Lan is aromatic and is similar to Huo Xiang.
- They accentuate each other and can be combined with Cang Zhu, Huo Po, Bai Dou Kou.
- Its nature is not dry, so it can be used for damp-heat in the Spleen.

Actions: Transforms dampness and releases summer-heat

Indications – for exterior damp-summer-heat patterns with nausea.

+ He Ye, Qing Hao

Main Actions:

- Transforms dampness and releases summer damp-heat

Dosage: 3-5 grams. Double the dosage when using fresh Pei Lan

Review questions:

- Compare Huo Xiang and Pei Lan.
- What herbs can release summer heat and summer damp-heat?